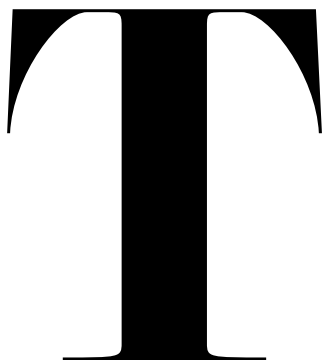




THERE WAS MUCH excitement on Delhi's posh MG Road—home to some of the biggest designer brands—this September, as a new store opened its doors to the city's discerning but affluent shoppers. While such unveilings are usually marked by a launch party where the glitterati rub shoulders over cocktails and canapés amid much fanfare, guests at this event were literally on their toes, as everyone was afraid of being the proverbial bull in a china shop!

82 | The store in question: Spanish luxury porcelain brand Lladró's glittering new outlet, replete with stunning sculptures priced between ₹8,000 and ₹2.47 crore. Now, that's not something you would want to trip and fall over.

Opened to celebrate the brand's 70th anniversary, it is Lladró's eighth store in India and the second largest in the world. Spread over 475 sq. m, it is part of the brand's expansion strategy in India and Asia. "India is a strategic market for us. It is third in terms of global sales; the first is Japan, followed by the US. Five years ago, India was 8 per cent of our global sales; today it is 11 per cent, so it's a big jump. I mean, we're seeing the Indian market growing so fast," says Ana Rodriguez, CEO of Lladró.

Lladró's journey in India began in 2000, with its first outlet in a suburban mall in Mumbai. Now, it has stores in luxury shopping malls across India in New Delhi, Gurugram, Hyderabad, Kolkata, Mumbai, Bengaluru and Chennai. "All these are managed by us as we believe that we have to invest directly in the country," says Rodriguez, who has been the CEO of the Valencia, Spain-based firm since 2017.

Globally, the brand has 1,200 points of sale.

The new boutique in Delhi is a massive five-storey building with three floors dedicated to direct sales, showcasing classic and contemporary porcelain figurines, lighting collections, and more. The ground floor showcases contemporary creativity under the New Concept line, including pieces designed by international artists, while the second floor highlights the traditional legacy of heritage pieces, and the third floor exhibits masterpieces under the High

Porcelain category, alongside a selection of New Classics.

Rodriguez says that in the two decades that Lladró has been present in the country, the tastes of its customers have also evolved, and the new store reflects that. Globally, it generates 69 per cent of its business from heritage concepts like high porcelain, classic sculptures, and home; 21 per cent from new concepts like design sculptures, scent and jewellery; while 10 per cent comes from lighting. "The younger generation is really appreciating the modern collections, which are away from our classics such as European history/culture, or themes of mother and child. So maybe in our minds, India is more conservative than it is," she says.

However, it is the 'Spirit of India' collection—that includes a wide range of deities from the Hindu pantheon—that continues to be the most popular. Launched in the 2000s with limited editions of Lord Ganesha, Lladró today offers everything from Goddess Durga, Lord Balaji and Lord Shrinathji sculptures to Radha-Krishna on a swing. The collection also includes the limited edition sculpture with only 299 pieces—of Krishna explaining dharma to Arjuna on the battlefield from the Mahabharata—called Gita Saar that took over three years to make, and is priced at ₹38.32 lakh.

The pandemic made most people more religious. Consider this: a surge in demand for Indian deity sculptures contributed to 37 per cent of India's business growth during the pandemic, with maximum demand coming for Lord Balaji—of which 299 units were launched in 2018. The price of the sculpture has increased by 38 per cent, from ₹18.5 lakh to ₹29.7 lakh since launch, with only five units remaining unsold in the world. In 2022, Lladró also launched a limited edition high-porcelain sculpture of Lord Srinathji—that received exceptional response from its Indian customers, retailing 54 units in just four months of the 299 units made. "The Spirit of India collection is popular not just in India but across the globe where there